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La Pizza House closes: So long to thin-crust pizzas, famous orange onion rings

BY JOANNE BOECKMAN • JBOECKMAN@DMREG.COM • AUGUST 4, 2010

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HOLLY McQUEEN/THE REGIS

Workers make onion rings for La Pizza House's last night Tuesday. From left are Cindy Renaud of Ankeny, a 37-year employee; Roy Shoning of Des Moines and Katie McWilliam Des Moines.

THE DES MOINES REGIS

Russ Reel, the owner and founder of La Pizza House, and h former partner Abbie Polito had this building constructed in

Russ Reel, owner of La Pizza House, turned 86 years old Monday and retired immediately after business Tuesday.

His decision meant closing down one of Des Moines' oldest pizza restaurants, laying off nearly 40 employees and leaving countless customers wondering where they would go for orange onion rings and thin-crust pizza.

"I guess 58 years is long enough," Reel said just before opening La Pizza House for the last time.

Reel and Abbie Polito, who have been friends since fifth grade, founded the restaurant in 1952 after a trip to a pizzeria in Omaha.

"I told him we could make this work in Des Moines," Reel said.

Their pizza was fine-tuned from a recipe of Polito's. They made everything in-house, including the salad dressing, breads and pizza crust. They hand-dipped tons of their curiously orange onion rings and breaded the chicken before deep-frying it.

"We always had to get onion rings with our pizza," said Ashley Moore, 25, of Ames. "Those onion rings were bright orange, which was kind of weird, but they were so good and they are the best I've ever had. Nothing else even comes close."

The color comes from using a yellow egg dye in the milk-and-egg batter. "It just made them look better," Reel said.

Moore's father, Michael Culver, 44, of Menlo, called the closing of La Pizza House "the end of an era."

Culver said the restaurant has been a family gathering spot for his family, including his grandparents, parents and his wife and children, for as long as he could remember. "We'll have to find somewhere else to go," he said. "It's kind of sad."

Polito and Reel first built their business in a brick house seating about 60 people and eventually had a line of customers outside. They had the current building constructed next door in 1960.

The restaurant seated more than 500: 160 on the first floor and 350 upstairs. The pizza, cavatelli and other foods were prepared and cooked in the first-floor kitchen. Onion rings - about 25 50-pound bags a week - were dipped and fried upstairs.

The second floor was a showcase for photos and trophies of the many fast-pitch softball teams sponsored by La Pizza House.

In 1993, Polito sold his share of the business to Reel and retired to Arizona. Three years ago, Veronica, Reel's wife of almost 60 years and his upstairs hostess, died.

In the past, La Pizza House delivered large orders of pizza to Titan Tire and to the legislators at the Capitol, said Rick Gregory, 59, a night supervisor at the restaurant.

"We even shipped pizzas around the country - as far away as New York City and San Francisco," said Gregory, a 12-year employee.

"This is sad," said employee Dominic Guidichessi, 75. "It's been a good ride for me, and I've made a good living." He started working in the kitchen at La Pizza House in 1957 and was its longest-tenured employee.

Reel's decision to close wasn't unexpected. He declined to renew the business's liquor license, and it expired three weeks ago. Customers caught wind of the possible closing and began flocking in. The restaurant ran out of some menu items Monday night.

In the past year and a half, business had declined, Reel said. Weekends were good, but weeknights were slow.

Reel was a hands-on owner, making pizza dough, working at the bar and helping at the cash register. He said he will miss his customers, who became his friends, and is sorry for employees who are losing their jobs.

He doesn't know what will happen to the building, which he refinanced a few years ago. He still owes about $200,000 on it.

Nor does he know what he will do. Immediate plans for Reel, a World War II veteran, include taking an honor flight to Washington, D.C., on Aug. 16. He plans to get in a few rounds of golf and some bowling with Gregory, the night manager.

"It's kind of hard to walk away," Reel said.

Russ Reel, 86, heads into La Pizza House restaurant, 1013 14th St. in Des Moines, on its last night of business Tuesday leaves behind many friends and families who have been con for years for the popular homemade food.

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